THE KEEFE TEAM · JLA REALTY · ALEDO, TEXAS

First-Time Home Buyers in Aledo & Weatherford

Buying your first home is mostly a vocabulary problem. Pre-approval, earnest money, option period, escrow, PMI. Nobody explains it, and then you're signing forty pages at a title company. This is the version we'd give our own kids. It's written for Parker County, where your first home might be a starter house in Weatherford, a townhome in Willow Park, or a small place with a little land, and we work all across DFW if your search takes you further.



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1. You probably need less down than you think

The 20% down payment is a myth that keeps a lot of renters renting. Conventional loans for first-time buyers start around 3% down. FHA is 3.5%. If you or your spouse served in the military, a VA loan can be zero down with no mortgage insurance, and that's a big deal in a county with as many veterans as ours. USDA loans are also zero down in eligible rural areas, which still includes a good bit of Parker County outside the city limits.

Texas also has down-payment assistance programs through TSAHC and TDHCA for buyers under certain income limits. A good local lender will tell you in ten minutes which of these you qualify for.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Ask a lender what you qualify for before you decide you can't afford it. Most first-time buyers are closer than they think.**

2. Get pre-approved, not pre-qualified

Pre-qualified means a lender guessed from what you told them. Pre-approved means they pulled your credit, looked at your pay stubs and bank statements, and will put a number in writing. Sellers in Aledo and Weatherford see both, and they only take the second one seriously.

Pre-approval also tells you your real monthly payment and lets you shop with confidence instead of hope. It's free, and the credit pull is a small, temporary dip.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Get pre-approved before your first showing. It's the difference between looking and buying.**

3. Know the whole monthly number

Your payment is principal and interest plus property taxes, homeowners insurance, and mortgage insurance if you put less than 20% down. In Parker County, taxes are a big piece: a home in Aledo ISD, Weatherford ISD or Brock ISD will carry a different rate, and the first year you'll pay based on the seller's exemptions, not yours. Add HOA dues if there are any, and on a place with a well and septic, a little set aside for maintenance.

We'll give you the full monthly estimate on any house you're serious about, so there's no surprise at closing.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Budget on the full payment, not the mortgage calculator number. The difference in Texas can be several hundred dollars a month.**

4. Where first homes actually are in Parker County

Weatherford has the most first-home inventory: older neighborhoods near downtown, newer subdivisions off I-20 and FM 51, and small acreage on the edges. Willow Park and Hudson Oaks have townhomes and smaller homes with Aledo ISD schools and a shorter drive to Fort Worth. Aledo proper and Walsh Ranch start higher, so first-time buyers there often look at smaller floor plans or wait a move. Springtown and Brock stretch the dollar further if you don't mind the drive.

Tell us where you work and what your life looks like and we'll tell you which three or four areas to focus on. Looking everywhere is how people burn out.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Pick your commute first. In Parker County, where you work decides where you should live.**

5. What to look at in a house (not the kitchen)

First-time buyers look at countertops. We look at the roof, the foundation, the HVAC, the water heater, the electrical panel and how water drains around the house. Those are the things that cost thousands. Paint and flooring cost hundreds. Jennifer spent a decade in construction and has renovated more than 20 houses, so you get a contractor's read on every showing.

Don't be scared of an ugly house with good bones. That's where first-time buyers find value.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Buy the house with the good roof and the dated kitchen. Not the other way around.**

6. The offer: what earnest money and the option period are

When you make an offer in Texas, you put down earnest money (a deposit held by the title company, usually about 1% of the price, credited back to you at closing) and an option fee, a smaller amount that buys you the option period: a few days where you can walk away for any reason and keep your earnest money. That's your inspection window.

We'll pull the recent sales and tell you what the house should go for. Then we'll build an offer that's competitive without overpaying, and in a multiple-offer situation, we'll tell you plainly whether to stretch or let it go.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Never waive the option period on your first house. The few hundred dollars it costs is the cheapest insurance you'll ever buy.**

7. Inspections: spend the money

A general inspection runs a few hundred dollars and looks at everything. On older homes we add a foundation specialist; on anything with a well and septic, we add those too. The inspection report will be long and scary. That's normal. We go through it with you, separate the real issues from the nitpicks, and negotiate repairs or a credit on the things that matter.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **Every house has a list. The question is whether the list has anything expensive on it.**

8. From contract to keys

After the option period, the lender orders an appraisal, the title company checks the ownership history, and you get your insurance lined up. About a week before closing you'll see the final numbers. On closing day you sign at the title company, wire your funds, and when the loan funds, you get keys. Usually 30 to 45 days from contract.

Between contract and closing: don't open new credit, don't finance a car or furniture, don't change jobs. Lenders re-check right before funding, and this is where first-time buyers get tripped up.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **No big purchases until the keys are in your hand. Not even the couch.**

9. After you close

File your homestead exemption with the Parker County Appraisal District (it's free and it lowers your taxes). Change the locks. Set up utilities. And then, because you're a Keefe Team client, our 16-foot enclosed trailer is yours for up to 7 days to move in, at no charge. Reserve your dates with us before closing.

> **Keefe Team tip:** **The homestead exemption is the easiest money you'll ever save. File it the first week.**

What you get from us

Straight answers, a contractor's eye on every house, local lenders who close on time, and two people who will tell you when to walk away from a house. We've helped a lot of first-time buyers, and we still remember being one.

Questions we hear most

How much money do I really need to buy a first home?

With a low-down-payment loan, roughly 3–5% of the price for the down payment plus 2–3% for closing costs, less if the seller contributes or you use an assistance program. On a $300,000 home that could be $15,000–$25,000 all in. Zero-down VA and USDA loans change that math a lot.

Should I wait for rates to drop?

Nobody can time it. If rates fall, you can refinance. If prices rise while you wait, you can't un-rise them. Buy when the payment works for your life, not when the news says to.

Who pays you?

That's spelled out in the buyer representation agreement we sign before we start, and it's often negotiated as part of your offer. We'll explain it plainly before you commit to anything.

Can I buy a house that needs work?

Yes, and it's often where the value is. FHA 203(k) and conventional renovation loans let you finance the repairs. Jennifer will tell you what the work really costs before you decide.

Ready to find out what you can actually afford? That conversation costs nothing.

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